The act also authorises the legislature of a state to make any provision for reservation of seats in any panchayat or offices of chairperson in the panchayat at any level in favour of backward classes.

The reservation of seats as well as the reservation of offices of chairpersons in the panchayats for the scheduled castes and scheduled tribes shall cease to have effect after the expiration of the period specified in Article 334 (which is presently eighty years, that is, till 2030).

It must be noted here that the above provision relating to the reservation of seats in panchayats (both members and chairpersons) for the scheduled castes is not applicable to the state of Arunachal Pradesh. This is because the state is inhabited fully by indigenous tribal people and there are no scheduled castes. This provision was added later by the 83rd Constitutional Amendment Act of 2000.

Duration of Panchayats The act provides for a five-year term of office to the panchayat at every level from the date of it's first meeting. However, it can be dissolved before the completion of its term. Further, fresh elections to constitute a panchayat shall be completed (a) before the expiry of its duration of five years; or (b) in case of dissolution, before the expiry of a period of six months from the date of its dissolution.

But, where the remainder of the period (for which the dissolved panchayat would have continued) is less than six months, it shall not be necessary to hold any election for constituting the new panchayat for such period.

Moreover, a panchayat constituted upon the dissolution of a panchayat before the expiration of its duration shall continue only for the remainder of the period for which the dissolved panchayat would have continued had it not been so dissolved. In other words, a panchayat reconstituted after premature dissolution does not enjoy the full period of five years but remains in office only for the remainder of the period.

Disqualifications A person shall be disqualified for being chosen as or for being a member of panchayat if he/she is so disqualified, (a) under any law for the time being in force for the purpose of elections to the legislature of the state concerned, or (b) under any law made by the state legislature. However, no person shall be disqualified on the ground that he/she is less than 25 years of age if he/she has attained the age of 21 years. Further, all questions of disqualifications shall be referred to such authority as the state legislature determines.

State Election Commission The superintendence, direction and control of the preparation of electoral rolls and the conduct of all elections to the panchayats shall be vested in the state election commission. It consists of a state election commissioner to be appointed by the governor. His/her conditions of service and tenure of office shall also be determined by the governor. He/she shall not be removed from the office except in the manner and on the grounds prescribed for the removal of a judge of the state high court [3]. His/her conditions of service shall not be varied to his/her disadvantage after his/her appointment.

The state legislature may make provision with respect to all matters relating to elections to the panchayats.

Powers and Functions The state legislature may endow the Panchayats with such powers and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as institutions of self-government. Such a scheme may contain provisions for the devolution of powers and responsibilities upon Panchayats at the appropriate level with respect to (a) the preparation of plans for economic development and social justice and (b) the